

Grim Fronteira

EUROPE DIED OF THIRST. THE OLD WORLD IS A FRONTIER AGAIN.

Grim Fronteira is a storytelling game set in Europe after the Great Drought, the catastrophe that broke the continent's spine. Three hundred years later, the land barely breathes again.

Criollos, Paisà, Yankees, and Chichimeca crossed back from the Americas chasing promises they half-believe. What they found was a land that remembers every sin.

Each player embodies a character bound to a suit of cards, carving their name into the Fronteira one scar at a time. They hunt Rewards, pushing their luck toward exactly **21 Reward points**. The winner takes the badge and becomes Marshal of the next tale.

The game combines freeform narration with blackjack resolution. You can stand together or stab each other in the back. The Fronteira decides who takes the badge and who rots unnamed.

What you need

A standard 52-card French-suited deck with one red Joker and one black Joker; a Marshal to narrate the world and resolve its challenges; and players to portray the characters. The browser app handles the deck, totals, and turn order.

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Browser app edition

These rules follow the browser app's frontend controls and backend rules, checked on 5 October 2026 against main/dev revision 02c539a2c773. The relevant scene and faction rules also match feature/post-deploy-polish revision 050bb197bd69. Earlier documents yield to the implemented app rules.

Rules by Yuri Bernardini & Mario Crea · UDS Studios
Adapted from the v1.2 rules PDF and the English Starter Edition.
Browser app rule source · English player edition · Revised 5 October 2026

Setup and faction powers

Lay out your character

The Marshal selects manual or random character assignment. Each player receives a Jack, Queen, or King; its suit determines the character's faction. Place the character card face up in front of you.

Jack: begin with 2 Scum cards.

Queen: begin with 1 Scum card and 1 Vengeance card.

King: begin with 2 Vengeance cards.

Starting resource cards come from the deck after the face cards have been separated. Keep Scum to the left of your character, Vengeance to the right, and face-up Rewards beneath it. Unchosen face cards return to the deck, which is shuffled when the game starts.

A Joker dealt as a starting resource remains in that pile. It does not grant extra starting cards in the browser app.

♦ Criollos - Law of Lead

Once per scene, turn **one of your Scum cards into Vengeance**, or **one of your Vengeance cards into Scum**. Choose the card to convert. The power is available to current scene participants and resets for the next scene.

♣ Paisà - Heart of Shadow

Choose and discard **3 Vengeance cards** to draw **1 Reward**. There is no once-per-scene limit; you need three cards, a living character, and a card left in the deck.

♥ Yankees - Order and Profit

Before a duel you are part of, inspect the top card of the deck. Choose **KEEP** to leave it on top or **BURY** to put it at the bottom. This happens before the initial player hands are dealt, once per participating Yankee per duel.

♠ Chichimeca - Children of the Earth

Whenever you take a wound, **steal 1 Scum** from a living opponent who has Scum. Choose the opponent; their top Scum card moves to your pile. The power triggers even on a lethal wound. If no eligible opponent has Scum, nothing is stolen.

Scenes and blackjack

When fists clench, guns rise, lies surface, or courage is tested, a scene begins. The Marshal chooses its participants and whether it is a trial, an NPC duel, or a player-versus-player duel.

Encounter difficulty

For a trial or NPC duel, draw one difficulty card. The target is **10 plus the card's value**: numbered cards use their face value; Jacks, Queens, and Kings count as 10; an Ace counts as 11.

A difficulty Joker sets the target to **20**. A red Joker gives every player 1 Scum card; a black Joker gives every player 1 Vengeance card. In the Dark, these bonuses wait until the hidden hand is revealed.

Play your hand

Your character card contributes **10 points**. Each participant receives one card. Highest initial total acts first; ties keep the Marshal's participant order. On your turn, choose to **draw** again or **stand**. Continue until you stand or bust.

2-10: printed value. **Jack, Queen, King**: 10.

Ace: 11, reduced to 1 when needed to avoid a bust.

Joker: 0 in a player hand; immediately gain 1 Scum for red or 1 Vengeance for black.

Match or exceed the difficulty without going over 21 to succeed. A total above 21 is a bust. In an ordinary encounter, a non-busting failure earns no Reward and causes no wound.

Spend Scum and Vengeance

Vengeance: play the top card of your pile for +1 to your own total, or **+2 if it matches your character's suit**.

Scum: play the top card of your pile for -1 to another participant's total, or **-2 if it matches your own character's suit**.

During play, participating players spend resources on their own turn before standing. Players outside the scene can also play Scum. You cannot target a busted player with Scum or use Vengeance after busting.

Before acknowledging a resolved scene, players can still use the resource actions available to them. These can change the provisional result. Spent cards are discarded when resolution is finalized. The Marshal may award bonus Scum or Vengeance for roleplay.

Wounds, healing, and Rewards

Busts and elimination

A bust causes **1 wound**, except when the Marshal busts through Azzardo. Busting does not also require discarding Scum, Vengeance, or a Reward in the browser app.

At **1 wound**, your character is wounded. At **2 wounds**, your character is eliminated. If all player characters are eliminated, the Marshal wins. A Chichimeca resolves their wound-triggered theft before play continues.

Heal between scenes

After Close Scene, a participant with exactly 1 wound and **more than 11 Reward points** must choose **Heal** or **Skip** before the next scene can open.

To heal, select Reward cards worth **at least 11 points** and confirm. Those cards are discarded and one wound is removed. Skip keeps the wound and your Rewards. Healing is unavailable during sudden-death endgame duels.

The app requires more than 11 points to offer healing, even though the selected payment may equal exactly 11.

Earn and count Rewards

Success in an ordinary encounter earns **1 face-up Reward**, drawn when the Marshal closes the scene. Success in the Dark earns 2. A normal player duel awards 1 Reward to the winner.

Reward values: **2-10** use printed value; **Jack, Queen, King** are 10; **Ace** is 11; **Joker** is 0. Reward points are separate from your scene-hand total.

Exactly 21 wins

Reach **exactly 21 Reward points** to win and become Marshal of the next tale. If multiple living players reach 21 at the scene's end, they enter sudden-death duels to decide the winner. Required Dark Reward losses settle before victory is decided.

Over 21: discard back to 20 or less

When the closed scene requires an excess-Reward discard, choose Reward cards one at a time until your total is **20 or less**. These cards go to the **discard pile**; they do not become Scum or Vengeance. Reaching 21 during this discard process does not win.

Complete any required Reward loss, healing choice, or excess discard before the Marshal opens the next scene.

Azzardo and the Dark

Azzardo: raise the stakes

Before an ordinary encounter starts, the Marshal may draw **one face-down Azzardo card** to add to the public difficulty. The browser controls offer this only when the difficulty card is numbered 2-10; an Ace, face card, or Joker blocks it.

The added card uses printed value, 10 for a face card or Joker, and 11 for an Ace. It stays hidden until resolution. Before starting, the Marshal may return it to the deck or start without Azzardo.

If the combined difficulty goes **over 21**, the Marshal busts. Every player who did not bust gains 1 Reward. Players who busted leave unharmed and gain no Rewards.

Azzardo is unavailable in the Dark and in player-versus-player duels.

Declare the Dark

The Marshal must declare the Dark **before drawing the difficulty card or choosing Azzardo**. Use it for trials or NPC duels when destiny bares its teeth; player-versus-player duels do not support it.

The Marshal's hidden hand begins with a base of **10** plus the difficulty card. They may draw additional hidden cards. This hand uses blackjack values: an Ace softens from 11 to 1 as needed, and a Joker counts as **0**.

If an extra card makes the hidden hand exceed 21, the Marshal **must discard that last card** before drawing again or revealing. They cannot discard a non-busting last card. The revealed Marshal hand cannot bust.

Reveal and resolve

Once every participant has stood or busted, the Marshal reveals the hidden hand. Match or exceed its total without busting to succeed.

Success: gain 2 Rewards when the scene closes.

Failure: take 1 wound and, if you have Rewards, choose 1 to discard after the scene closes. Busting and failing in the Dark do not cause two wounds for the same loss.

Each Joker still in the Marshal's revealed hand grants its color's bonus to every player: red gives 1 Scum; black gives 1 Vengeance. A Joker discarded from the hidden hand grants no reveal bonus.

Duels and the next scene

Player-versus-player duels

A player duel involves exactly **two characters** and uses no Marshal difficulty, Azzardo, or Dark. Each character begins with their face card's 10 points plus one drawn card, then plays in the normal turn order.

The higher non-busting total wins. If one character busts, the other wins. In a normal duel, the winner gains 1 Reward and the loser takes 1 wound, even if the loser did not bust.

If both characters reach **21**, they leave as friends: no Reward and no wound from that result. Other tied totals, or both players busting, cause a rematch. Bust wounds already taken remain; a rematch does not erase them.

Deck exhaustion and sudden death

If the draw pile runs out during a scene, ordinary scene Rewards are not dealt. Among surviving characters, the one with the most Reward points wins. A tie for the lead, or several players reaching exactly 21 together, starts sudden-death duels.

Tied contenders duel in pairs until one remains. Sudden-death duels grant **no new Rewards** and offer no healing. Ties, including both players reaching 21, cause a rematch. The discard pile can be reshuffled to continue the tie-break.

Reshuffling

For ordinary encounters, when scene cards are cleared at Close Scene, a Joker in the discard pile causes the discard pile to be shuffled back into the draw pile. Cards still held as characters, resources, or Rewards stay with their owners.

A Joker draw does not immediately reshuffle the deck. Player-duel cleanup follows its separate procedure; rematches and sudden-death rounds reshuffle discards as needed.

Finish the scene in the browser

Resolve: after players have stood or busted, review the provisional outcome and any remaining Scum or Vengeance reactions.

Acknowledge: participants confirm the result when ready.

Close Scene: the Marshal finalizes the scene and deals Rewards.

Next Scene: available after required Reward losses, healing choices, and excess discards are complete.

If a faction power asks for a choice, resolve it before ordinary play continues. A paused game or lost connection also blocks gameplay actions until the session is ready.

“The sun sinks over the Fronteira. Whoever still stands becomes the Law of the Desert.”